

AZRA UP TO BAT

ZOE CARVER

MICHAEL WAS SHORT. This didn't surprise Azra, she wouldn't let it. She felt herself flinch slightly, an internal squeeze, but she tried to keep her face as neutral as possible. He was short. Men are short. It happens.

"Ass-ara?" Michael asked, his face pulled into a tense smile.

"Azra," she corrected. He wrapped her in the most awkward of hugs, a clammy coffin as her nostrils filled with sweat-stained cotton. He came up to approximately her nose.

"You know, I'm so glad we could actually, like, find a time to meet up," he said, sitting back down at the table where she'd found him, enjoying a plate of greasy tater tots drenched in a red-wet ketchup. "So many girls you talk to and talk to, but when you finally ask to meet up? Nothing.

"Oh, totally," Azra replied absentmindedly. She found her way onto the uneven wooden chair, feeling herself wobble as she slid too far to the left, then too far to the right. Back and forth, back and forth, the hind leg would lift and she could concentrate on the slow rhythm rather than Michael's height.

Really, it shouldn't bother her that much. Should it? She didn't feel like she was all that picky when it came to men. Easy to please, all she needed was someone not too chiseled,

not too lean, not too bright, and not too basic. Somehow, Michael felt like all of those things.

The pictures on his profile hadn't been bad; she'd convinced herself there was some potential. A picture with a dog, a picture on a hike, a picture at a work party. He reminded her of a plasticity neighbor that would show up in the back of a car commercial to complement the new Toyota. Docile, unassuming, with a beard, a midsize frame, and swoopy brown hair that just barely missed his eyes. Normal enough. She'd swiped right.

Almost immediately, she was met with a message:

Sup, baby girl. Winky emoji.

Azra typed out, *not much, wbu?*

From there, it had been a quick snare and capture.

"-and that's why I think the Mets are going to at least make it to the playoffs, you know? It's their year-"

Azra ordered a drink.

"-and my sister, she's like, a total bitch. But ever since she got into medical school, my parents have been all up her ass-"

Azra ordered another drink.

"-and I told my boss, I told him. If he ever tried to give Janice *my* corner office? I would just walk out."

Azra felt the room start to tilt into fuzziness. Was this her fourth? Might've been her fifth. She knew she'd need to sober up, and fast. But by god, Michael was unbearable. She'd played this little song and dance long enough to know that the mating call of men on dating apps was douchebaggery.

Michael was on his second beer, a craft IPA. She was sure that he noticed her slight wobble, the droopiness that now befell her. She tried to concentrate, focusing on a discolored mole above his lip. What were the ABCs of cancer? Asymmetrical, benign, coloration. She squinted; perhaps a closer look could decipher if it was melanoma or just a passing

speck. It wouldn't matter either way, Azra knew. Not for Michael. Not after tonight.

"So, do you go on lots of dates?" He asked. This was the first question he'd asked her in the last hour. It wasn't a question she particularly liked.

Azra dipped her finger in the small pool of condensation that had sweated off her cup, drawing it across the table in the shape of an X. "Oh, a normal amount. I'm still trying to find something that's right for me."

"Yeah, I was seeing this girl for a while, but her friends were soooo weird-"

Azra thought about what Calliope would say about him. *Just do it already. Get it over with.* She always wanted to jump straight to the point.

"-and my prized baseball. She didn't even like my prized baseball. It's literally signed by Jacob deGrom." Michael paused, like she was supposed to know who that was. "Would you like to... uh... see it? My baseball, I mean. It's back at my apartment."

Oh, this was pathetic.

"Sure."

Get it over with. You can put on a show.

They finished their drinks. Azra swayed as she stood, her legs like stilts daring her to stay still. She felt the cool crawl of Michael's hand fighting its way to her waist. Another repressed flinch. They walked out.

Lights blurred in and out of focus, the car headlights and neon advertisements like the lush strokes of an oil painting. Azra breathed the night air in with a gulp, like a hand had been on her throat, pushing, pushing. A slight chill ran down her back, little fingers trilling their way back up her spinal cord. Pulling.

"Wanna walk or take a cab?" Michael asked, wrapping his

arms around himself. He wore jeans and a shirt with a flannel on top, no jacket. Idiot.

“Walk,” Azra instructed curtly. She would’ve run ahead of him, if she could, though she wasn’t supposed to know where his apartment was. He guided her down a side street, then a left, then a right. He talked as they walked, about his friends, his work, the government, his high school sweetheart. She let his words wash over her, in one ear and slowly trickling out the other. It would all be over soon. He would be done, and she would be complete.

Michael stopped in front of a brutalist apartment building with cement balconies attached to a deteriorating fire escape. The blinds were drawn in all the windows, lights long extinguished as tomorrow’s promise of school, work, the rush of the city buses, beckoned sleep forward.

“Come on,” Michael nodded towards the door. He took her hand and led her up.

Blood rushed through Azra’s veins, circulating the arteries around her heart, which told her firmly, stoically: she was ready.

Later, back at her own apartment, Azra took her longest shower in recent memory. She needed the steaming water to become one with her body and give her new skin. She washed it off, all of him, all of Michael, everything he’d touched. She gripped herself as the burning water turned her red, flashes from the night leaving her frozen.

She needed to pull herself together. This is what Calliope wanted her to do. *It’ll be good for you. Empowering.* Calliope was usually right.

She stepped out of the bathroom and into her chic studio apartment that looked over the city. Calliope had

recommended this place to her, helped her with the leasing agent. Azra had never brought a man here, not in the two months since she'd moved in. Home was sacred. And besides, you don't shit where you eat.

It hadn't always been like this for Azra. She'd started out in a three-bedroom with five roommates in the part of town where it wasn't quite safe to walk late at night, or early in the morning. The girls had been loud, tired, overworked, and filled with a vile sort of hatred for the city that kept pushing them and pushing them. They had been dead. Azra had been like them, dead too, tired, angry, still going by her birth name. *Alyssa*. The same name that was on the lease for this new apartment. One last tie to before.

It had been a shaky night, the one where she'd met Calliope. Stumbling, she'd left through the back door of a bar into a dimly lit alley, slick with rain. There was Calliope, talking to a tall man. A beautiful, tall, god-like man. The type of man Azra used to spend hours daydreaming about, worshiping, wishing he'd notice her. She was forever falling in love with strangers back in those days.

Blurring into Azra's vision was Calliope, all angles, sporting a skimpy dress of a deep emerald, batting her eyelashes and twirling her hair. A girl made to feed fantasies. She'd seen Azra standing at the edge of the alley, and their eyes met, sending a jolt through Azra's spine. So quickly Calliope had changed, from smooth and malleable to harsh intelligence. Scarily quick.

She was solid and she was in control.

"Hey," Azra called dumbly. Emboldened by alcohol, she fantasized about flirting with the man. About taking him home and letting him do whatever he pleased.

Calliope smiled that sour smile Azra would soon become quite familiar with, and led Azra stumbling away, leaving the man in the shadows. "You good, sister?"

"I'm... I'm good. I just..." She was at a loss. She wanted to talk to the man melting into the alley. She didn't like the feeling of Calliope on her arm. It reminded her of her roommates, always telling her to *chill the fuck out, girl*.

"You're lost, honey," Calliope cooed. "It's ok, I used to be lost too. All you need is a bit of Sisterhood." The strange woman pressed something into Azra's palm. Azra found herself pushed back into the bar, the sharp coolness of the street dispensing in the club's vapid heat.

The next morning, Azra's drunken fog cleared to find Calliope's business card pressed in the space between her bra and her dress. A small divet had appeared in her pink flesh from the point of the card. It didn't say Calliope's name on it, just a bright X, *The Sisterhood*, and a phone number.

Azra scoffed. Mormons? Yoga retreatates? She didn't care to find the answer.

She went to work, hungover and bleary-eyed. At the office, she typed typed typed away, putting the good care of her expensive liberal arts communications degree into action. In the monotonous hum of emails, she thought about the man from last night. Then she thought about the guy who worked in the cubicle two down. Then she thought about the boy with the scruffy beard who'd given her her morning bagel. Men lived inside her like parasites.

She knew it was an issue: she was at their whim, like a boot on a neck. She didn't know what made her so powerless around the opposite sex. She didn't know how to stop.

As she poured coffee in the break room, she thought about texting the man she'd been seeing late at night, in and out of her bedroom door. She'd latched on to him because it was easy, because he was a three and she was a six, despite the way he treated her. They slept together regularly, like the dead, and each time Azra was left with the faint feeling of something rotting in her liver. Still, he was better than nothing, the cool

emptiness of her room. Anything was better than the silence, and so she filled herself with men, close and constant. Love was a game she lost over and over again, like the turn of a merry-go-round. The men could smell her desperation; they always knew they had the upper hand. New faces, but the same ghost story. She let herself be used.

Azra thought about the business card on her bedside table. Maybe if she called the mystery girl, she could find her way back to that man from the alley. It's not like she had anything to lose.

Azra called. Calliope picked up.

That night, Azra traveled to Calliope's apartment in the new and terribly fashionable part of the city, where heiresses and startup bros alike shared their dwellings.

"Alyssa?" Calliope had said upon meeting her. "Now that just won't do."

She smiled something sinister and dragged Azra inside.

Now, Azra had three missed calls from Calliope, each one a blaring red alarm. Five texts. *How did it go?* Replayed with different wording. Azra groaned. She wanted to go back to sleep. She thought of Michael last night, how he'd looked. Naked. Small. The smell of pleasure and fear bleeding from both of them.

She'd done what Calliope had told her to do.

Calliope had explained, that night when they'd next met, how to play the game, this modern dating. *It's all about mindset. You're dealing yourself the losing cards.* Calliope taught the reborn Azra how to win.

And Azra won last night with Michael. There was no question about that.

She remembered from before, the morning-after panic of

will he text me again? Did I do it right? Will there be a second date? Now, all Azra felt was a cool emptiness. Was this what she wanted? Detachment for empowerment. Companionship for sisterhood. Hot, choking horror for release. Was it truly worth it?

No, no, she couldn't start thinking like this. She'd given everything to join Calliope. To become a *Sister*. She'd learned to detach herself from the men who used to fill her every moment. She'd learned to set herself free. The Sisterhood had given her everything; they had hugged her, brought her in, taught her how to be. It was splendor. It was indulgence, and all for the low, low price of herself. She was becoming who she was meant to be.

Knock, knock.

Calliope, Azra knew even before she looked through the peephole. They now lived only a block away from each other, and she was prone to dropping by unannounced. Unavoidable as death, Azra opened the door.

"Darling, how *was* your night?" Calliope had that smirk on her face, the oh-I'm-just-popping-bye ease. Azra didn't buy it. Everything about the woman was intentional.

"It went as planned."

"Oh good, the girls will be so pleased to hear." Calliope gave her a sly glance, "And... well, how was it? Everything you dreamed?"

"It was quick," Azra answered curtly. "I was in and out."

Calliope rolled her eyes, "Ever the pessimist. Wasn't it empowering? It just makes me feel like such a *woman*. That's what the Sisterhood is here for."

"To find our womanhood in spaces that had been taken from us, yada yada yada. Yes, I feel empowered. Yes, I have a whole new perspective on life. Yes, I am a new woman. Yes, yes, yes."

"You should be more grateful for the Sisterhood, you

thankless cunt,” Calliope smiled through Azra’s offhanded reply.

Azra’s mouth clamped closed.

“Come on, let’s go to lunch.”

Azra sulked silently over her egg and corn salad. The truth was, she wasn’t so sure about the Sisterhood anymore. It was so *much*. The apartment, the seminars, the weekend getaways where they talked about their divine femininity. They’d taken her under their wing, done all these nice things for her, and all they asked for in return-

Azra thought she wanted to pay the price. Now, all she wanted were some carbs.

“This is too much anticipation,” Calliope said finally, “You have to give me more details. What was he like?”

“Short.”

“Oh, please, aren’t they all?” Calliope rolled her eyes. “I want juice. Gossip. What did it feel like?”

Azra thought back to last night in tiny flashes. Him. Her. His bedroom, with its Mario Kart and Anime posters. Unwashed laundry ripe in the corner, daring her to comment. She drew a quick huff, “Good. Really, it felt good.”

“Tell me the truth.”

“Not here.”

“Why not here? Afraid of getting yelled at by our *waiter*? A *man*?”

Calliope was teasing her. She was always teasing her. Azra had felt like she deserved it before last night, because Calliope had something she didn’t. Now it just felt akin to picking at a scab just to see it bleed.

“Fine. It felt good last night. I liked it. But waking up this morning? I just feel... guilty.”

Calliope scoffed, "Guilty? Please, Azra, I thought you were better than that. Guilt is for religious fanatics and prudes. We are Sisters. We take what we want."

She was quoting the Sisterhood seminar pamphlet, one of her more annoying habits.

"What next?" Calliope continued. "You're gonna tell me you feel *dirty*?"

"Stop-"

"Want me to call you a sinner? Gonna cry to mommy? Act like an adult, for the love of god."

"I don't know if I can do this," Azra huffed, looking away from Calliope. "I think it might all be... a little much."

Flares of rage passed in the woman's eyes like an eclipse. She lunged forward, grabbing Azra's arm, acrylic nails digging in like daggers, "Remember how it felt, Azra. Without all this whiny bitch shit. Put that away and remember. Remember who you were last night. You were empowered. You were a Sister. You were *alive*."

Azra swallowed and nodded. Calliope plastered back on her famous sour smile, letting Azra's arm go. Tiny specks of blood bloomed in the half-crescents Calliope had created.

"So anyway, I'm thinking of hot yoga next Monday," Calliope continued, as if flakes of Azra's skin were not now tucked into her nailbeds.

Maybe Calliope was right. Azra was being a coward. What had happened with Michael... it had scared her, yes, but it had also thrilled her. She was just getting too deep in her head, as per usual. What had happened had been a good thing for her. The start of a new era.

"You're right," Azra said to Calliope as they walked back to their apartments, "I'm just being a bitch."

"Oh darling, shock is natural," Calliope embraced her in a squeezing hug. "That's why I'm here and all your Sisters. We're a family."

Azra smiled. Last night had been worth it. It had to have been.

In truth, the night before had been magical.

Michael had led her to his bedroom, kissing roughly as they went. He'd taken off his flannel briskly in the doorway, expecting her to do the same. She removed her jacket, her shoes, her low-cut sweater. She kept her purse close.

"Oh baby," Michael said in a voice lower than his own, removing his shirt. A growl, almost. Azra wanted to laugh in pity, but she kept up appearances, kissing his neck. Scruff dug into her lips.

He is John from work. He is the bagel guy on 2nd Street. He is the man in the alley. Azra told herself. *He is every man who has ever had control.*

They crawled onto the bed, Azra's legs straddling Michael's small body. She tried not to think about it. This was her chance. To prove she was truly a Sister and a woman. Everything Calliope thought she could be. This would make everything make sense. This would make Azra Azra.

Michael started to unbutton his pants. Azra eyed his storied baseball in a glass case in the corner of the room. *Come on*, it seemed to say. *Play ball*. The time was now. Azra reached into her purse, still slung across her body. The time was now. From the bag, she grabbed the rather large pink switchblade Calliope had gifted her the night before. The time was now. She raised it above her head.

"What the fuck?"

Strike.

Azra watched as blood poured from the wound in Michael's chest. Warm. How easily it had punctured, how awfully clean the smooth skin had broken. He looked up at

her in utter shock, disgust blooming on his squished-in face. She struck again.

“You... bitch...”

And again and again and again. She could still feel the alcohol in her own bloodstream, daring her to go further. God, this was it. This was everything.

Michael’s blood pooled underneath her. She dipped her finger in it, drawing a faint X across his chest. Fingerprint. She started to laugh, an uncontrollable, bubbling sound from deep in her chest. She’d done it. She was severing men from her life, all men, every man. She was becoming Calliope, she was becoming a Sister, she was centering her divine femininity and she was severing every man who had ever dared.

For once, Azra was in control. Well played, well played.

This was it. The corpse, slowly turning cold, the rush of adrenaline pumping in Azra’s ears. This was everything. The Sisterhood had told her it would be this way. She felt like a goddess in a story of old, smiting at her own will. She wanted to lick the blood off of Michael’s body, she wanted it to infuse with her own. She was the master. She was the one in charge. She was a cat and the world of men was a world of mice. Tiny, crawling, squealing creatures .

She felt empowered. She felt like a queen. She felt, for once, really and truly-

Alive.